

# The Path

September 20, 2026

*Version 1.0*

*The order things arrive in, and why the order is not negotiable*

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## **Abstract**

Maschina is broad by design, and breadth has one characteristic failure, which is a shallow version of everything. This document sets out the stages in order, the single rule that prevents that failure, what each stage must demonstrate before the next begins, and what is refused permanently.

## 1. The rule that governs everything

Nothing is built that does not reuse the spine: custody, budget, record, identity, execution.

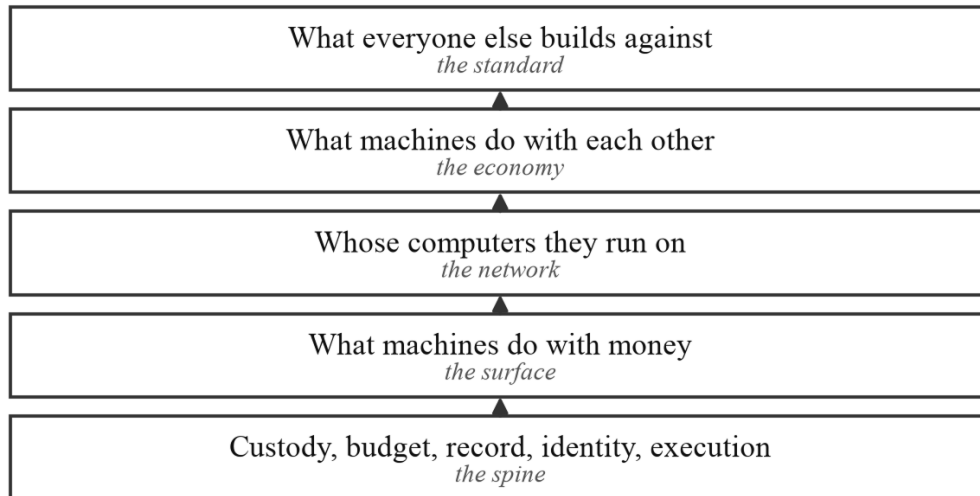


Figure 1. Every layer exists because of the one beneath it.

A platform of this scope fails in one specific way, and the rule above is the defense against it. A capability that cannot be expressed through the spine is not a capability Maschina offers, regardless of how attractive it looks or how quickly a competitor ships it.

## 2. Why custody comes first

A machine that trades is straightforward, and many exist. A machine a person will fund and then ignore is not, and that is the product.

Building custody first means that for a period the system has every guarantee and very few tricks. It looks backwards from outside and it demonstrates poorly. It is the correct order anyway, because capability added to a trustworthy foundation is engineering, while trust added to a capable system is a rewrite that nobody ever actually performs.

## 3. Stage one: the machine

A machine with its own wallet and an enforced policy. A budget held and settled at true cost. A mandate checked before signing. Signing, single send, and settlement read back from the chain. Nodes that claim work under leases and cannot forge and record. Monitoring that queues work when a condition is met. A public interface.

**Demonstrated when** a machine funded with real money on a live market acts correctly, records what it did and stops when told.

#### 4. Stage two: the surface

Every form of execution and every kind of position. Machines that close what they opened, work a range, rebalance, provide liquidity, stake, and put idle balances to work. Mandatory asset checks with continuous monitoring. Simulation, so anyone can operate a machine before risking anything.

**Demonstrated when** an owner can express any ordinary intention about their own money as a machine, and see it measured against the benchmark of doing nothing.

#### 5. Stage three: the product

Sign-in with a wallet. The application. Plain language direction of machines. The statement of account an owner reads each morning and can hand to anybody.

**Demonstrated when** somebody who has never seen this creates, funds and understands a machine without assistance.

#### 6. Stage four: the market

Publishing, copying, renting and selling machines. Creators earning while copies run. Standing computed from records. Capacity priced by auction. Bonds behind published machines.

**Demonstrated when** somebody who did not build Maschina earns a living from a machine they built on it.

#### 7. Stage five: the network

Execution on contributed hardware. Verified work. Compute and bandwidth sold. Distance from decision to landing published and falling.

**Demonstrated when** most machine work runs on hardware Maschina does not own, and the published latency beats the alternative.

#### 8. Stage six: the economy

Machines delegating, paying, hiring, insuring and competing. Credit extended to machines on the strength of their records. Capital markets where people fund machines they do not own, with a jurisdiction and a structure established before any line of code.

**Demonstrated when** a machine's record is accepted as evidence by somebody deciding where to put money.

#### 9. Stage seven: the standard

The policy format, the record format and the machine definition implemented by other people, with Maschina as the reference implementation and the settlement layer.

The most valuable position is not owning the application. It is being the thing every application of this kind is built against.

## **10. Refused permanently**

Operating a chain. Issuing a token before real usage exists to denominate it. Taking custody of user funds. Publishing returns that did not occur or projections presented as expectations. Any capability that requires weakening the three refusals.

## **11. On timing**

Stages overlap, and dates are intentions rather than commitments. The order is a commitment. Each stage is the foundation of the next, and attempting a later one early produces exactly the thing these papers exist to avoid: a platform that is broad, shallow, and trusted with other people's money.